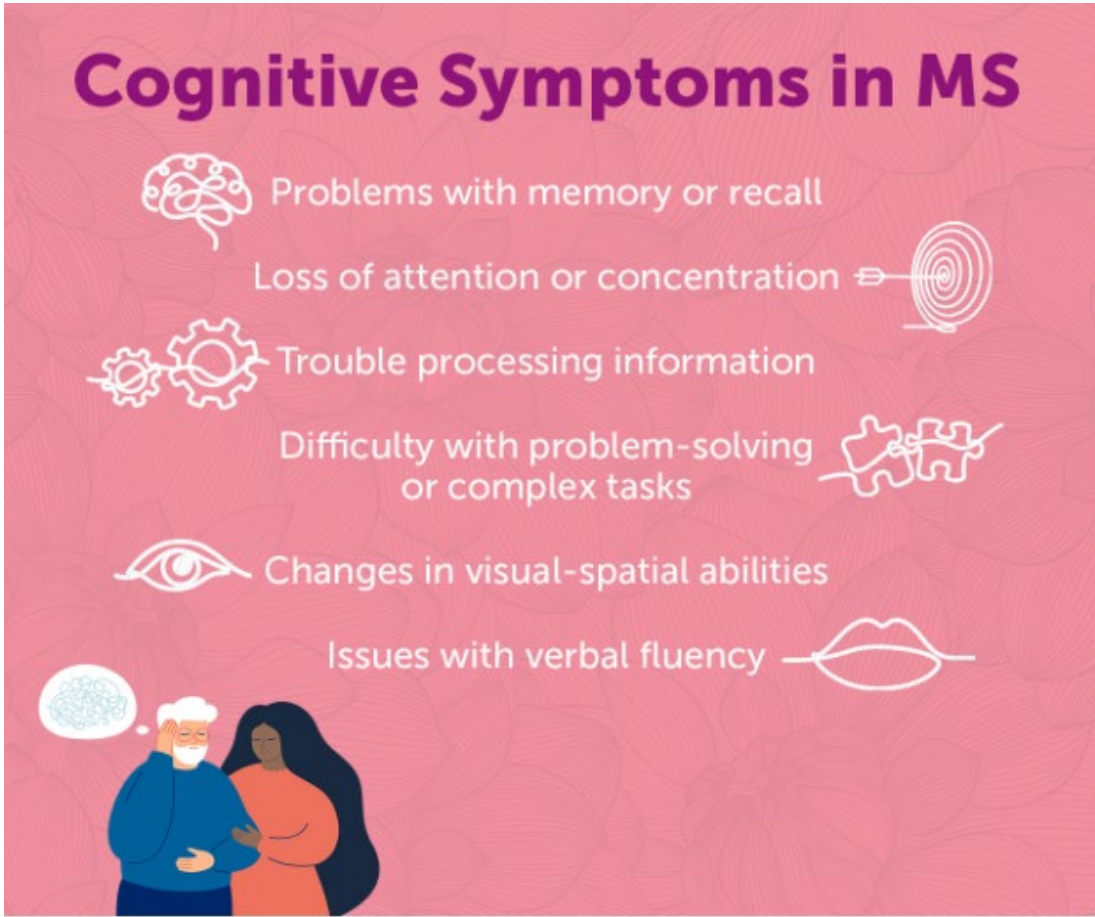


Background

Health literacy is one of the main social determinants of health affecting outcomes. Low health literacy is considered a key source of economic inefficiency in the U.S. healthcare system ¹. It is estimated that inadequate health literacy adds an additional 106 to \$238 billion cost to the health care system ²

- Cognitive function is associated with health literacy, independent of education and other important confounders³
- Multiple sclerosis (MS) is a progressive disease of the nervous system that causes physical and psychological debilitation and involves cognitive decline , and a decline in cognitive abilities could lead to a patient's decreased understanding of their condition and medication, impaired processing of information, and reduced ability to follow instructions
- A standardized method to identify patients with low health literacy who could benefit from additional, tailored education is lacking

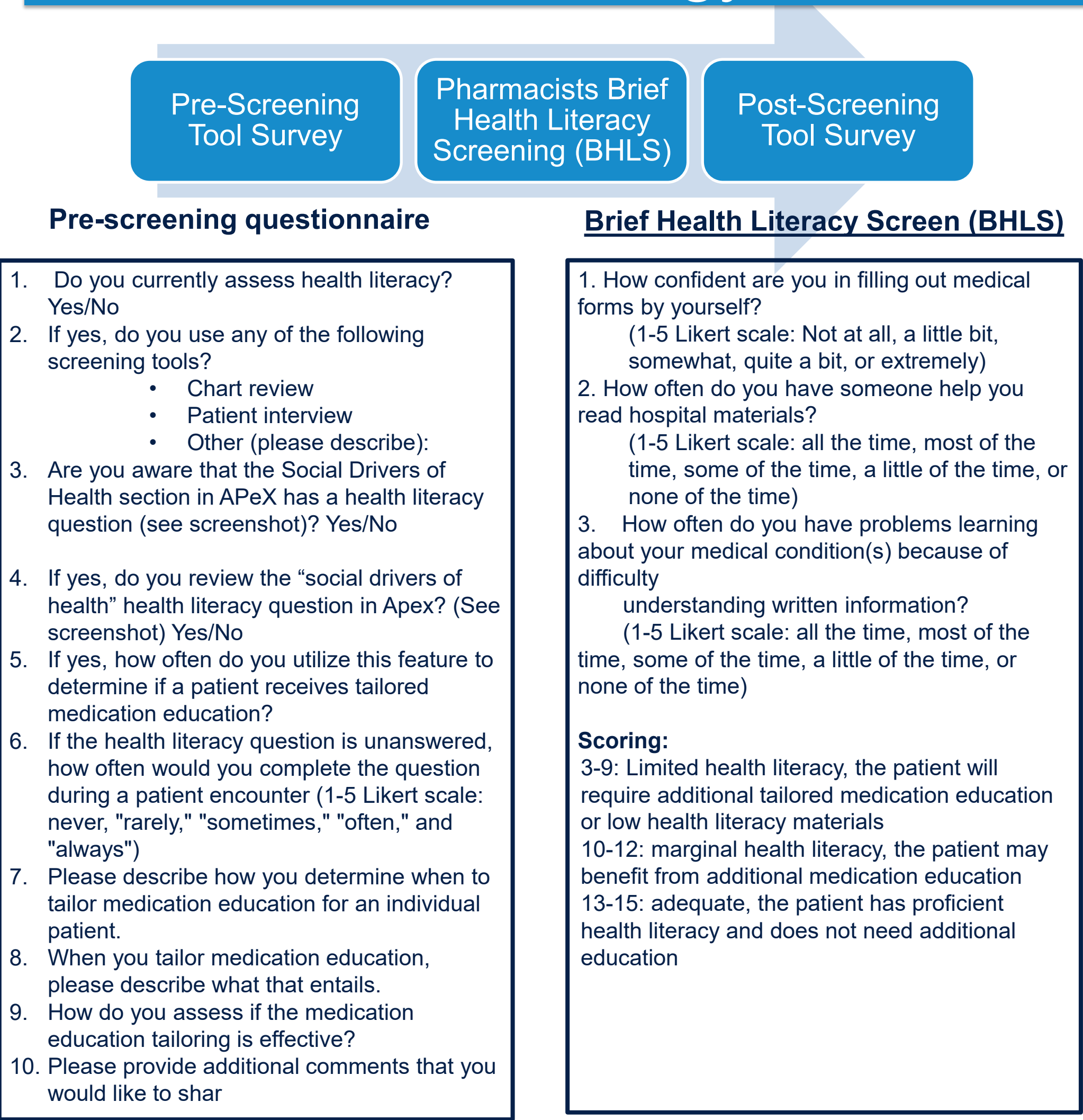


<https://www.mymsteam.com/resources/dementia-and-multiple-sclerosis-is-there-a-connection>

Objective

Develop a health literacy screening tool that focuses on the patient's understanding of their condition, other than comprehension or arithmetic, and can identify patients who may benefit from additional education

Methodology



Post-screening questionnaire

1. How helpful was the screening tool in identifying patients who may benefit from tailored medication education? (Not helpful, somewhat helpful, very helpful)
2. How did you implement the screening tool into your patient interactions?
3. How likely are you to continue using the screening tool in your everyday practice? (Not likely, likely, very unlikely)

References:

1. Rasu RS, Bawa WA, Suminski R, Snella K, Warady B. Health literacy impact on National Healthcare Utilization and expenditure. Int J Health Policy Manag. 2015;4(11):747–55.
2. <https://bmchealthservres.biomedcentral.com/articles/10.1186/s12913-022-08527-9>. accessed 7/25/2025
3. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0168822713002179#>; accessed 7/25/2025

Results

- N=11 pharmacists practicing in MS clinic
- 86% (n=9) of respondents currently assess health literacy
- 18% (n=2) do not currently assess health literacy

Table 1. Pre-Screening Tool Survey Responses Regarding Health Literacy Screening Practices

Item	Response	Percentage (n)
Screening tools currently used	Chart review	83% (5)
	Patient interview	83% (5)
	Other (undefined)	17% (1)
Awareness of “Social Drivers of Health” Section in APeX	Yes	12% (1)
	No	88% (7)
Review of “Social Drivers of Health” Section in APeX Prior to Patient Education	Yes	0% (0)
	No	100% (1)
Frequency of Answering “Social Drivers of Health” Section in APeX	Never	64% (5)
	Rarely	12% (1)
	Often	12% (1)
	Always	12% (1)

Table 2. Post-Screening Tool Survey Overall Themes

Item	Response	Percentage (n)
Likelihood of Using Screening Tool in Everyday Practice	Rarely	17% (1)
	Never	83% (5)

Theme	Representative Quotes
Lack of Supporting Resources	“3/4 said less likely due to lack of resources, i.e., if they scored low on the assessment, aside from adjusting the consultation, what other resources do we have to support these patients?” “Without materials like multilingual handouts, pictorial instructions, or a standardized follow-up plan, it’s hard to apply this consistently across providers.”
Incomplete Workflow and Guidance	“The workflow feels incomplete. While giving pharmacists discretion makes sense in theory, the lack of structured guidance, resources, or workflows creates uncertainty around how to intervene effectively after screening.” “Leaving next steps up to individual judgment without direction makes it difficult for the project to gain traction or be scalable in practice.”
Need for Standardized Follow-Up	“I’d recommend developing a basic framework or toolkit to support pharmacists once a patient with limited health literacy is identified.”

Conclusion

The findings of this study indicate that while majority of the pharmacists found the BHLS helpful, but there is the need for a standard procedure once patients are identified as having low health literacy. Development of standardized handouts or medication education materials would help guide pharmacists to provide better care for their patients. Future research should focus on addressing limitations and exploring the proposed future directions to enhance the effectiveness of the BHLS.